

# TIOBE Index March 2026

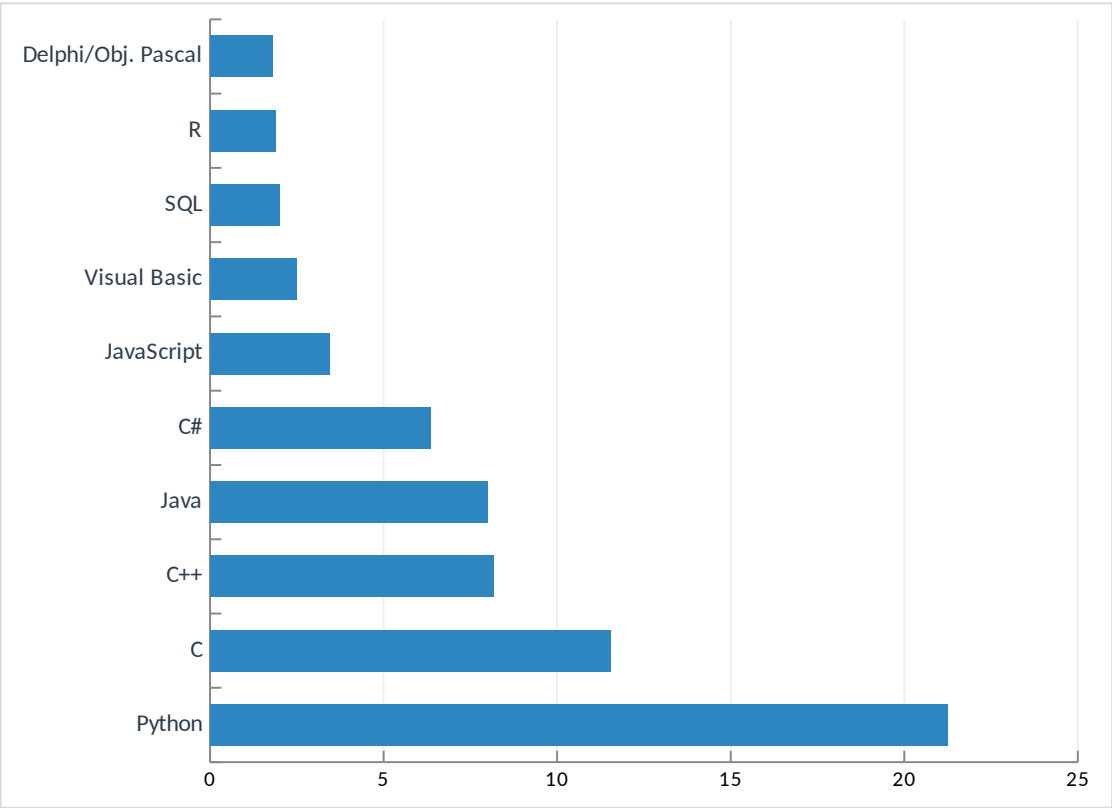
## How 20+ Search Engines Rank the World's Programming Languages

The TIOBE Programming Community Index is updated monthly since 2001. Ratings are calculated from the number of skilled engineers worldwide, training courses, and third-party vendors, using search-engine hit counts across Google, Bing, Wikipedia, Amazon, and 20+ other sites.

**Audience: Software Engineering Leads & Technology Strategists**

Source: [tiobe.com/tiobe-index](https://tiobe.com/tiobe-index) | Captured April 10, 2026

# Python Holds #1 at 21.25% but C Surges to #2 with the Largest Gain



The top 4 languages -- Python, C, C++, Java -- collectively account for nearly 49% of the total index.

| #2026 | #2025 | Language           | Rating | YoY Change |
|-------|-------|--------------------|--------|------------|
| 1     | 1     | Python             | 21.25% | -2.59%     |
| 2     | 4     | C                  | 11.55% | +2.02%     |
| 3     | 2     | C++                | 8.18%  | -2.90%     |
| 4     | 3     | Java               | 7.99%  | -2.37%     |
| 5     | 5     | C#                 | 6.36%  | +1.49%     |
| 6     | 6     | JavaScript         | 3.45%  | -0.01%     |
| 7     | 9     | Visual Basic       | 2.50%  | -0.02%     |
| 8     | 8     | SQL                | 2.00%  | -0.57%     |
| 9     | 16    | R                  | 1.88%  | +0.94%     |
| 10    | 10    | Delphi/Obj. Pascal | 1.80%  | -0.36%     |
| 11    | 24    | Perl               | 1.75%  | +1.05%     |
| 12    | 12    | Scratch            | 1.63%  | -0.03%     |
| 13    | 11    | Fortran            | 1.45%  | -0.25%     |
| 14    | 14    | Rust               | 1.31%  | +0.09%     |
| 15    | 15    | MATLAB             | 1.29%  | +0.31%     |
| 16    | 7     | Go                 | 1.29%  | -1.49%     |
| 17    | 17    | Assembly           | 1.29%  | +0.42%     |
| 18    | 13    | PHP                | 1.23%  | -0.25%     |
| 19    | 18    | Ada                | 1.10%  | +0.25%     |
| 20    | 26    | Swift              | 1.04%  | +0.44%     |

# Perl Jumps 13 Spots, R Climbs 7, and Go Drops 9 -- The Biggest Rank Shifts of 2026

## GAINERS

**Perl**

+13 spots

24th -> 11th | +1.05%

Entrenched in infrastructure & text processing

**R**

+7 spots

16th -> 9th | +0.94%

Data science & statistical computing demand

**C**

+2 spots

4th -> 2nd | +2.02%

Largest absolute rating gain in top 5

**Swift**

+6 spots

26th -> 20th | +0.44%

Apple platform growth; re-enters top 20

## LOSERS

**Go**

-9 spots

7th -> 16th | -1.49%

Sharpest decline; possible Rust displacement

**C++**

-1 spot

2nd -> 3rd | -2.90%

Largest percentage-point drop in top 5

**Java**

-1 spot

3rd -> 4th | -2.37%

Continued long-term decline from peak dominance

**Python**

-2.59pp

#1 (held) | -2.59%

Still dominant but posting notable erosion

# From Lisp at #2 in 1986 to Python at #1 in 2026: How Language Rankings Shifted Over Time

| Language   | 2026 | 2021 | 2016 | 2011 | 2006 | 2001 | 1996 | 1991 | 1986 |
|------------|------|------|------|------|------|------|------|------|------|
| Python     | 1    | 3    | 5    | 7    | 8    | 26   | 17   | -    | -    |
| C          | 2    | 1    | 2    | 2    | 2    | 1    | 1    | 1    | 1    |
| C++        | 3    | 4    | 3    | 3    | 3    | 2    | 2    | 2    | 9    |
| Java       | 4    | 2    | 1    | 1    | 1    | 3    | 31   | -    | -    |
| C#         | 5    | 5    | 4    | 5    | 7    | 11   | -    | -    | -    |
| JavaScript | 6    | 7    | 8    | 10   | 10   | 8    | 33   | -    | -    |
| Go         | 10   | 11   | 60   | 16   | -    | -    | -    | -    | -    |
| Ada        | 14   | 36   | 25   | 22   | 16   | 18   | 6    | 10   | 3    |
| Lisp       | 26   | 34   | 26   | 13   | 14   | 19   | 8    | 4    | 2    |

## Python

Unranked before 1991 -> #1 in 2026. Took 25 years to reach the top.

## C

The only language in the top 2 across all nine measurement points spanning four decades.

## Java

Dominated 2005-2018, now fallen from 25%+ to under 8%.

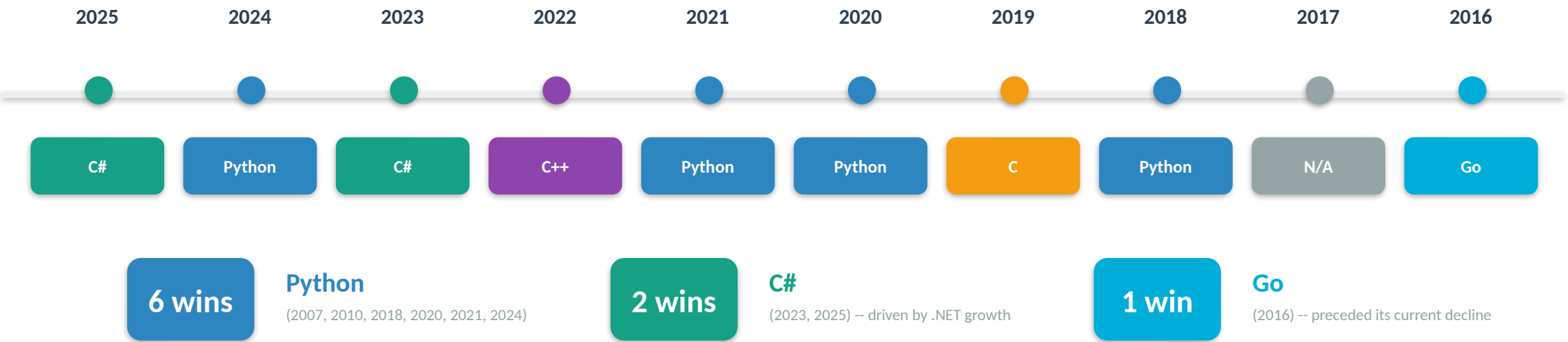
## Lisp

Was #2 in 1986, now #26 -- one of the most dramatic long-term declines.

JavaScript's plateau: Despite web-development dominance, JavaScript has never exceeded ~5% on TIOBE and currently sits at 3.45%.

# Python Wins Language of the Year 6 Times -- More Than Any Other Language

The TIOBE "Programming Language of the Year" award goes to the language with the largest gain in ratings during a calendar year.



Note: 2017 winner data is not available in the source.

# The Top 4 Languages Hold 49% of the Index: What This Means for Your Tech Stack

## Python: Dominant but Declining

At 21.25%, Python leads by a wide margin -- yet its -2.59pp YoY decline is the largest drop among the top 5. Monitor for continued erosion before doubling down on Python-only strategies.

## C's Resurgence

C surged from 4th to 2nd with +2.02pp -- the largest absolute gain. Embedded systems, IoT, and performance-critical workloads continue to drive demand.

## Legacy Language Revival

Perl jumped 13 spots, R climbed 7, Fortran remains top 15. Entrenched communities in scientific computing, data analysis, and infrastructure show no signs of fading.

## Go's Sharp Fall

Go dropped from 7th to 16th (-1.49pp) -- the largest decline in the top 20. Possible displacement by Rust (14th, +0.09%) in the systems programming space.

## Concentration Risk

Python, C, C++, and Java collectively hold 48.97% of TIOBE ratings. Diversifying language investments reduces exposure to single-ecosystem shifts.

**Align hiring, training, and tooling investments with these trends to stay ahead of industry momentum.**